MMM! A Middle-School Mentoring Model to Improve School Outcomes for Disengaged 6th Grade Students

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Introduction

Purpose

Researchers at the Institute on Community Integration received funding from the Extension-CEHD Block Grant Program to develop and pilot the Middle-School Mentoring Model (MMM!), an afterschool small-group mentoring program to increase student engagement and foster positive youth development. The program was piloted at a high-poverty, K-8 Minneapolis Public School during the 2012-13 school year.

Based on Check & Connect (C&C), a comprehensive student engagement intervention developed at ICI and included in the Institute of Education Sciences What Works Clearinghouse as an evidence-based intervention (WWC, 2006), MMM! was designed to promote student engagement through relationship building, problem solving, and persistence for marginalized students. MMM! supports positive youth development by promoting relationships with caring adults and peers that lead to strengthening students' affective and cognitive engagement with school and learning, thus reducing problem behaviors and increasing academic engagement in school. This design aligns with the ongoing mission and research interests of the Extension Center for Youth Development.

Broader implementation of C&C is currently limited by the cost of providing one-on-one mentoring to students who need it. We hypothesized that it would be possible to achieve most or all of the benefits of C&C in a small group setting that *systematically* leverages informal peer support to supplement the positive influence of the adult mentor.

Research Questions

1. To what extent does participation in MMM! increase student engagement in school (measured by attendance, behavior, grades, and the Student Engagement Instrument)?
2. What are teachers' perceptions of benefits to student participants in the program?
3. What are parents' perceptions of benefits to student participants in the program?

Project Goals

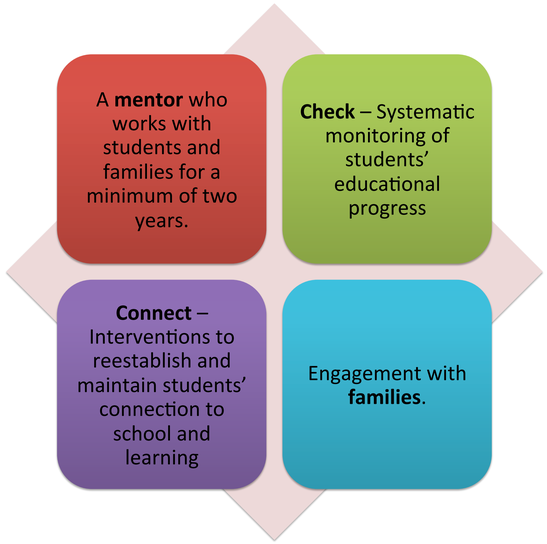
1. Increase students' attendance to 90% or better.
2. Decrease problem behaviors (suspensions, behavioral referrals, detentions) to two/year or less.
3. Improve student grades.

Development

Adaptation of Check & Connect

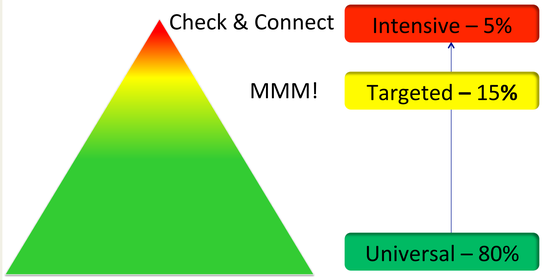
Check & Connect is a structured mentoring program designed to enhance student engagement at school and with learning for marginalized, disengaged students in grades K-12, through relationship building, problem solving and capacity building, and persistence.

Check & Connect consists of four components, each of which was included in MMM!. Additionally, MMM! Included the small group as a 5th core component.



Tier 2 Intervention

Check & Connect is designed to complement universal, tier 1 strategies. Check & Connect can be conceived of as both a tier 2 and 3 intervention, but most often targets students with more intensive needs and so is a tier 3 intervention. MMM! targets students showing initial signs of disengagement and can be considered a tier 2 intervention.

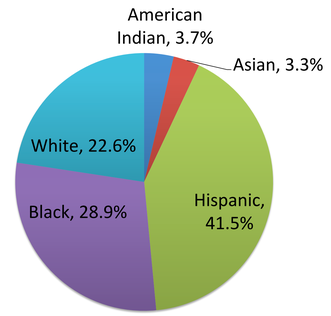


Methods

Setting

- Minneapolis Public Schools K-8 school
- 913 students
- 86% of students on Free/Reduced Price Lunch

Folwell Demographics



Participants

- 30 – 6th Grade students identified as exhibiting initial signs of disengagement (a combination of attendance below 85%; two or more behavior referrals per month; and/or reading and writing below grade level)
- Participants were divided into two groups, each with approximately 11-13 students (allowing for attrition)

Intervention

Frequency and Duration

- Group A met Mondays and Wednesdays 3:15-5:15
- Group B met Tuesday and Thursdays 3:15-5:15

Group Schedule

- 3:15-3:30 Snack in cafeteria
- 3:30-3:45 Group circle meeting (discuss celebrations and successes, discuss current event)
- 3:45-4:30 Learning time (homework help, skill building)
- 4:30-4:45 Self-monitoring of progress and goal setting
- 4:50-5:15 Choice time in gym or computer lab

Content

- MMM! provided : 1) Tutoring, specifically in academic success skills, and 2) Mentoring to address motivation-to-learn.

Measures

- Student evaluation taken by 16 participants
- Student Engagement Instrument
- Grades, attendance, office referrals

Findings

Research Questions and Goals

Unfortunately, due to constraints such as lack of data received from the district, inconsistent attendance by participants, and poor response rates from parents and teachers, we were unable to answer our research questions or provide quantitative results for project goals. Our findings are discussed in terms of student evaluation and researchers' conclusions.

Student Evaluation

- All participants strongly agreed or agreed that they enjoyed attending MMM!
- 15 out of 16 participants strongly agreed or agreed that they would sign up for MMM! If offered again.
- Comments about what they liked included:
  - Learning things we want and every time we have a meeting we get better at knowing that we have to earn things that we want and need
  - Getting homework done
  - Having fun
  - Having snacks, playing games, and making friends
  - Having different choices
- Comments about what they didn't like included:
  - The groups of Monday/Wednesday, and Tuesday/Thursday (preferred attending daily)
  - Other people not being nice
  - People talking
  - Change in mentors in February

Conclusions

- A small group model is a Tier 2 intervention; it does not work well for students who need intensive Tier 3 support, particularly behavioral support.
- The afterschool setting is not conducive to an intervention that depends upon peer support because attendance is not mandatory. MMM! requires consistent attendance for group cohesion
- The time spent in the small group needs to be highly structured while still flexible enough to respond to any specific student issues that might arise.
- A small group adaptation of Check & Connect may be more appropriately implemented with high school students who are developmentally ready to honestly discuss their school performance and experiences and problem solve with their peers.
- We believe our original hypothesize to be true – that that it is possible to achieve most of the benefits of C&C in a small group setting, but more research is needed to further test this hypothesis.